If we want to display the properties of all the books in our view, we can do so with an ERB template like this:

```
<h1>Listing Books</h1>

<table>
  <tr>
    <th>Title</th>
    <th>Summary</th>
    <th></th>
    <th></th>
    <th></th>
  </tr>

<% @books.each do |book| %>
  <tr>
    <td><%= book.title %></td>
    <td><%= book.content %></td>
    <td><%= link_to "Show", book %></td>
    <td><%= link_to "Edit", edit_book_path(book) %></td>
    <td><%= link_to "Remove", book, method: :delete, data: { confirm:
"Are you sure?" } %></td>
  </tr>
<% end %>
</table>

<br>

<%= link_to "New book", new_book_path %>
```

The actual rendering is done by subclasses of `ActionView::TemplateHandlers`. This guide does not dig into that process, but it's important to know that the file extension on your view controls the choice of template handler. Beginning with Rails 2, the standard extensions are `.erb` for ERB (HTML with embedded Ruby), and `.builder` for Builder (XML generator).

2.2 Using `render`

In most cases, the `ActionController::Base#render` method does the heavy lifting of rendering your application's content for use by a browser. There are a variety of ways to customize the behavior of `render`. You can render the default view for a Rails template, or a specific template, or a file, or inline code, or nothing at all. You can render text, JSON, or XML. You can specify the content type or HTTP status of the rendered response as well.

If you want to see the exact results of a call to `render` without needing to inspect it in a browser, you can call `render_to_string`. This method takes exactly the same options as `render`, but it returns a string instead of sending a response back to the browser.

2.2.1 Rendering Nothing

Perhaps the simplest thing you can do with `render` is to render nothing at all:

```
render nothing: true
```

If you look at the response for this using cURL, you will see the following:

```
$ curl -i 127.0.0.1:3000/books
HTTP/1.1 200 OK
Connection: close
Date: Sun, 24 Jan 2010 09:25:18 GMT
Transfer-Encoding: chunked
Content-Type: */*; charset=utf-8
X-Runtime: 0.014297
Set-Cookie: _blog_session=...snip...; path=/; HttpOnly
```